

GE261004 DESIGN THINKING

Unit III – Ideation and Creative Thinking · Presentation 1 of 6

Idea Generation Techniques

What ideation is for · why quantity comes first · a map of the techniques · running a session · the four things that kill one

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- Quantity before quality
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1

What ideation is for

A deliberate search for options, not a discussion about which to pick

What ideation is – and is not

- A deliberate, time-boxed search for options – not a debate about which one to take
- It runs against one framed question, usually a How Might We from Unit II
- Judgement is not abolished; it is postponed to a separate step that comes later
- It ends with a wide field of options, not with a decision

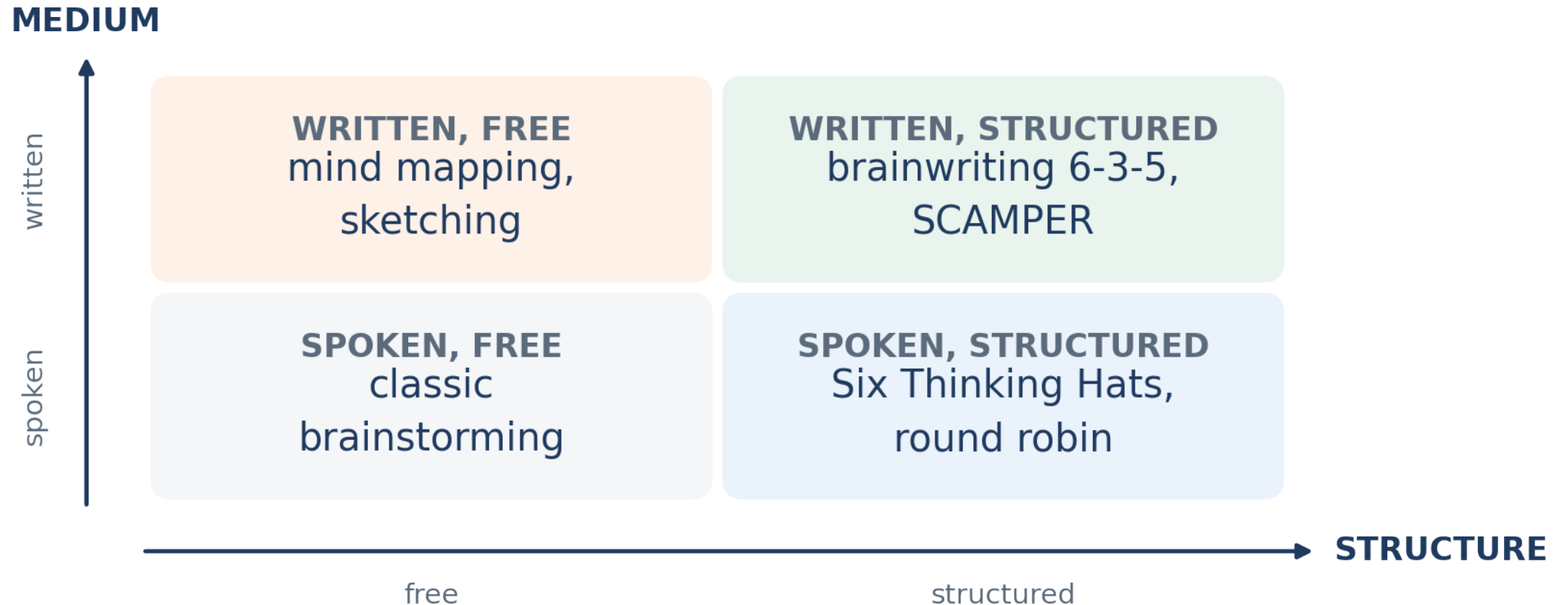
KEY POINT If people are arguing about whether an idea will work, you are not ideating any more. You have started converging.

Quantity before quality

- The first ten ideas are the obvious ones – everybody in the room already had them
- The unusual ideas only appear once the obvious ones are out of the way
- A weak idea is often the raw material for somebody else's strong one
- So set a number, set a clock, and do not stop when the room goes quiet

KEY POINT Aim for a hundred ideas in an hour. You are not choosing yet, so a bad idea costs you nothing.

A map of the techniques



Four quadrants, and this unit visits all of them.

Three shapes of session

Solo first

Everyone writes alone before anyone speaks. Protects the quiet and the unusual.

Group together

Ideas build on each other out loud. Fast and social – and easily dominated.

Solo, then group

Write alone, then share and build on each other. What most sessions should do.

KEY POINT Start alone and finish together. Starting together loses every idea that was not spoken first.

2

Running a session

Most of the work happens before anyone says an idea

Before the session

- One framed question, written large, on the wall where everyone can see it
- Six to eight people, including at least one who is not an engineer
- Materials out and ready: markers, sticky notes, a wall, a visible clock
- A facilitator who has agreed not to contribute ideas of their own

KEY POINT The question on the wall decides everything that follows. Spend real time writing it before anyone arrives.

During the session

- Warm up for five minutes on something silly and completely unrelated
- Read the rules aloud – they only work if the room has agreed to them
- One idea per note, written large enough to read from three metres away
- When the flow slows, call a new angle: a constraint, an analogy, a reversal

ACTIVITY Forty-five seconds each. Name one use for a brick. No repeats, no judging, no pauses – keep going until the timer stops.

After the session

- Photograph the wall before anybody moves a single note
- Cluster the notes as a group, and name each cluster in a full sentence
- Mark the wild ones, and carry at least one of them into every later round
- Agree the next step and who owns it before the room empties

KEY POINT An unsorted wall of ideas decays into nothing within a week. Cluster on the same day, while the room still remembers.

Four things that kill a session

The senior person speaks first

Everyone anchors on that idea and the room has narrowed within two minutes.

Judgement arrives early

One “that will not work” and the unusual ideas stop being offered at all.

One person talks throughout

Production blocking: while one person speaks, five others are not writing.

No constraint at all

A question with no edges produces vague ideas that nobody can build on.

The facilitator

Does

- Keeps time out loud
- Enforces the agreed rules
- Writes no ideas of their own
- Calls a new angle when flow dies

Does not

- Contribute their own ideas
- Rank anything during the session
- Let one voice dominate
- Let it run past the clock

KEY POINT A facilitator who joins in stops being a facilitator, and the room loses its referee at the moment it needs one.

THINK ABOUT IT

When did you last stay quiet in a group because your idea sounded silly?

- What made the room feel unsafe for it?
- Would you have written it down if nobody had to hear it?
- Who in your team is quietest, and what are you losing?
- What would you change about how your team generates ideas?

Summary

- Ideation is a timed search for options, with judgement postponed
- Quantity comes first – the good ideas live past the obvious ones
- Techniques vary by medium and by how much structure they impose
- Start alone, then build together; the reverse loses ideas
- Prepare the question, the people and the materials in advance
- Cluster the same day, and keep one wild idea in every round

Next: Brainstorming and brainwriting

- Where brainstorming came from, and its rules
- Why brainstorming so often underperforms
- Brainwriting 6-3-5 and how it fixes that
- Three other written methods worth knowing